(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Side effects of an IUD (intrauterine device) or copper coil

Side effects of an IUD

After you get an IUD fitted:

- you might have some period-like pain for a few days
- you may have some bleeding between your periods
- your periods may become heavier, longer or more painful – this may improve after a few months
- you have a small chance of getting thrush that keeps coming back – talk to your GP if this happens

Your partner should not be able to feel your IUD threads during sex. If they can and it's a problem, see a doctor or nurse to get the threads checked.

> Find out about choosing a method of contraception (Link: www.nhs.uk/contraception/choosing-contraception/), including side effects and risks of different methods.

How well an IUD works

An IUD is over 99% effective at preventing pregnancy.

This means that less than 1 in 100 women using an IUD as their method of contraception get pregnant each year.

Risks of an IUD

An IUD is very safe, but there are some rare risks, including:

- pelvic infections, usually within 3 weeks of having an IUD fitted
- your IUD moving or coming out, usually within 3 months after it's fitted
- damage to the womb
- ectopic pregnancy (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/ectopic-pregnancy/) in the rare case that your IUD fails

Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from NHS 111 if:

You've had an IUD fitted and:

- you have pain in your lower tummy (abdomen) and painkillers do not help
- you get sudden pain in your lower tummy that gets worse or does not go away
- you have a high temperature
- you have abnormal or smelly discharge
- you have very heavy vaginal bleeding
- you think you might be pregnant
- you cannot feel the threads of your IUD, or they feel different

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/).

If you cannot feel your IUD threads

If you cannot feel the threads when you check for them you might not be protected against pregnancy, and you may need emergency contraception (Link: www.nhs.uk/contraception/emergency-contraception/).

Use another form of contraception until a doctor or nurse has checked your IUD.

More in IUD (intrauterine device) or copper coil (Link: www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/iud-coil/)

What is an IUD? (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/iud-coil/what-is-it/)

Where to get it (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/iud-coil/where-to-get-it/)

Who can get it (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/iud-coil/who-can-get-it/)

Getting it fitted or removed (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/iud-coil/getting-it-fitted-or-removed/)

Side effects and risks

Page last reviewed: 15 February 2024
Next review due: 15 February 2027